

“Kim” by Rudyard Kipling [B2]

Nessuno sembra accorgersi che Kim, che vive per le strade di Lahore, ha origini irlandesi. Sarà proprio la sua conoscenza di questi due mondi che lo porterà a vivere una serie di avventure incredibili.

Joseph Rudyard Kipling was born in 1865 in Mumbai (then known as Bombay) in what was then British India. He spent much of his earliest childhood with his Indian ayah — or [nursemaid](#) —, and spoke the Bombay [vernacular](#) in preference to English. While he was still very young, his parents sent him to a [boarding school](#) in England for five years, where he was [bullied](#) and badly treated. This experience probably contributed to his extreme sensitivity and [lifelong](#) love of India.

RETURN TO INDIA

Kipling returned to India in 1882. As his parents belonged to the highest rank of Anglo-Indian society, he was familiar both with that world and with the rich, colourful culture of native India. He worked for seven years as a journalist, often contributing prose [sketches](#) and poetry. He soon published collections of poems and short stories, which became hugely popular. Kipling’s imperialist ideology is controversial today, but few question his genius as a writer. The novel Kim, considered his masterpiece, is [set against](#) the colonialism of British India in the late-19th century and focuses on the geopolitical tensions between European powers in central Asia, a situation referred to in the novel as “the Great Game”. The book has been called a spy story, a [quest novel](#), and a [coming-of-age novel](#). Above all, it is Kipling’s love letter to India and a celebration of the sounds, smells, and colours of that country.

KIMBALL O’HARA

Kim tells the story of Kimball O’Hara, the young, orphaned son of an Irish regimental soldier who has grown up as a [street urchin](#) in Lahore. Known

simply as Kim, no one suspects that he is white: “Though he was burned black as any native; though he spoke the [vernacular](#) by preference, and his mother-tongue in a clipped uncertain sing-song; though he consorted on terms of perfect equality with the small boys of the bazar; Kim was white — a poor white of the very poorest.” “Anche se era nero bruciato come un indigeno qualsiasi, anche se parlava di preferenza il vernacolo e la lingua materna in una cantilena incerta e zoppicante, anche se si sentiva perfettamente a suo agio con tutti i ragazzini del bazar, Kim era bianco... un povero fra i più poveri bianchi.” Classic Books

“Heart of Darkness” by Joseph Conrad Questo racconto in lingua inglese dello scrittore polacco Joseph Conrad, pubblicato 120 anni fa, è una dura critica all’immoralità e all’ipocrisia del colonialismo in Africa. Il suo messaggio risuona con forza ancora oggi. Daniel Francis , Alex Phillips, Sarah Davison

INDIAN SOUNDSCAPE

Kim’s dialogue is written in this [vernacular](#), and the story is so [peppered](#) with dialect words that the reader is immediately immersed in the [soundscape](#) of British India at the [turn of the century](#). The story begins when Kim, who is playing on the streets of Lahore, encounters a Buddhist lama. The boy is immediately fascinated by the lama’s words and actions: “Kim followed like a shadow. What he had overheard excited him wildly. This man was entirely new to all his experience, and he meant to investigate further, precisely as he would have investigated a new building or a strange festival in Lahore city. The lama was his trove, and he purposed to take possession.” “Kim lo seguì come un’ombra. Quello che aveva udito lo aveva riempito di eccitazione. Per lui, nonostante tutta la sua esperienza, quell’uomo costituiva una novità assoluta e voleva continuare a studiarlo: così come si studia una nuova costruzione o una festa insolita nella città di Lahore. Il lama era una sua scoperta, ed era deciso a prenderne possesso.” A 19th-century postcard of Victoria Terminus train station in Bombay (Mumbai).

BUDDHIST DISCIPLE

Kim volunteers to be the lama's chela — or disciple —, helping him on his quest for [enlightenment](#) as he seeks the legendary Arrow River spoken of in tales of the Buddha's life. Together they travel across India on the Great [Trunk](#) Road, encountering a cast of vivid characters as they go. Although Kipling's ideas about empire and race are of his time, the book can also encourage appreciation and admiration for cultural difference. The boy Kim is full of [wonder](#) and enthusiasm for the diversity of life and its experiences. Known by all as The Little Friend of all the World, Kim considers India to be what he calls "the broad smiling river of life." He walks with his lama through a carnival atmosphere where the only discourtesy is demonstrated by a functionary of the empire: "Kings could be no richer. He bought sweetmeats in a leaf-cup from a Hindu trader and ate them with glad rapture until a policeman ordered him off the steps." "Un re non poteva essere più ricco. Comprò da un mercante indù qualche dolcime avvolto in una foglia e lo divorò beato, finché un poliziotto non gli ordinò di sgombrare i gradini."

THE PERFECT SPY

In a parallel [plot](#), Kim becomes involved in espionage and delivers a secret letter containing vital geopolitical intelligence to the British. Kim's natural ability to [slip unselfconsciously](#) between cultural identities makes him the perfect spy. He prefers local food and sleeps [curled up](#) like an Indian boy. He has an Indian vagueness about time and an ability to [sleep through](#) loud noise. And yet he has the white man's fear of snakes, a certain white arrogance, and a white respect for orders. After many adventures and tribulations, the young Kim faces a choice between two identities: to continue in the Great Game as a spy and employee of the colonial service, or to remain a disciple of the lama and to share in his [enlightenment](#).

CONTROVERSY

Like many of his time, Kipling had imperialist [persuasions](#). He has, with some justification, been accused of being a reactionary, a racist and a [vicious](#) anti-Semite. And yet, this is not the whole story. To the end of his life, he continued to write some of the finest prose and verse ever produced in English. Kipling published his best-known work in the 1890s and early 1900s, for example, the novels *The Light That Failed* (1890) and *Kim* (1901), and his collections of stories *The Jungle Book* (1894) and *The Second Jungle Book* (1895). When he received the Nobel Prize for Literature in 1907, he was the first English language author to do so and, at forty-one, the youngest. After World War One, Kipling's extraordinary popularity started to diminish as he began to be viewed as a [jingoistic](#) imperialist. As he grew older, he became increasingly isolated. When he died, however, in 1936, his [ashes](#) were [interred](#) in the privileged location of Poets' Corner in Westminster Abbey.

Glossary

- **soundscape** = paesaggio sonoro
- **slip** = scivolare
- **curled up** = rannicchiato
- **persuasions** = convinzioni
- **interred** = seppellire
- **bullied** = bullizzare
- **set against** = contrapporsi, avere come sfondo
- **enlightenment** = illuminazione
- **plot** = trama
- **unselfconsciously** = spontaneamente
- **ashes** = ceneri
- **lifelong** = di tutta la vita
- **coming-of-age novel** = romanzo di formazione
- **turn of the century** = fine del secolo
- **Trunk** = tronco, proboscide
- **sleep through** = dormire nonostante
- **jingioistic** = nazionalista, sciovinista
- **vernacular** = lingua vernacolare, dialetto
- **boarding school** = collegio, scuola privata
- **sketches** = bozze
- **quest novel** = romanzo d'avventura, di ricerca
- **wonder** = stupore
- **vicious** = brutale
- **nursemaid** = bambinaia
- **street urchin** = ragazzo di strada
- **peppered** = disseminare